'I ADMIRE RAHUL GANDHI'S FITNESS'

***Hima Das,** India's first and only athlete to win a gold medal at an international track event, talks about her preparation for the 2023 Asian Games, her views on Rahul Gandhi's Bharat Jodo Yatra, and Shah Rukh Khan's* Pathaan



VIVEK R NAIR

Q. How are you preparing for the Asian Games? Can we expect another gold medal?
I am training in Kerala, away from public interaction. At the moment, I'm doing only endurance training and not targeting any specific medal.... My focus is always on improving the timing. If that happens, medals come automatically.

Q. You often talk about keeping the Assamese community united. What's your opinion on Rahul Gandhi's Bharat Jodo Yatra, which also seeks to promote unity?
Irrespective of its political goal, the Yatra is inspiring for me as a message for physical fitness. I'm impressed with the way Rahul Gandhi has walked the long distance. That he could survive only in a T-shirt in extreme cold shows how important fitness is. People should learn from that. My home state Assam's chief minister, Himanta Biswa Sarma, is also an example of fitness. He often walks such long distances.

Q. When you are not running, how do you keep yourself occupied?
I love cooking. I read religious books. I play an instrument called 'khol'.

Q. Any plan to join MasterChef in future?
I don't know about that but certainly I want to showcase my culinary skills as I'm a good cook. I want to start a restaurant in Guwahati.

Q. What's your opinion on the film boycott brigade? Will you watch Shah Rukh Khan's *Pathaan*?
That will depend on the reviews. While artists and film-makers should respect public opinion as it's people's appreciation that makes them great or successful, boycotting a film based on the colour of clothes is not acceptable. It's everyone's democratic right to watch or not watch a film. Nobody can force such a decision.

with Kaushik Deka